S/V WINDIGO

Welcome aboard Windigo. She’s a South African made 60-foot performance catamaran. She’s currently the only Balance 580 in the Caribbean. She’s a unique boat. We hope you have a great time onboard and get to love her as much as we do.

While this is your holiday, you’re also part of the crew. That’s not meant to be dramatic (well maybe a little!). This is a participation-holiday. While we can relax and have a great time, we also have a shared responsibility to work together to stay safe and share boat work.

The experience works best when everyone participates. If something needs doing and you’re able to help, just help. If you see a line out of place, tidy it. If we’re anchoring, be ready to assist. If dishes are stacking up, jump in. Passive passengers create work. Active crew make this enjoyable.

Relax, swim, read, nap — but stay engaged. That balance is what makes this kind of trip great.

The Basics

The ocean is not hostile, but it is indifferent. The boat will take care of us if we take care of the boat. While we have a general itinerary for each trip, things can change. Weather will dictate our days. We have to go with the flow. We may have to hide in a bay and let a storm pass, or play cards while it rains.

Jean-Michel's responsibilities include navigation, weather, sail trim, anchoring, safety, and managing the systems, itinerary planning. Your responsibility is awareness. If something doesn't look right or feel right, say it early. Small issues are easy to manage. Large ones are not.

We could lose water, power, or break things. The good news is that Jean-Michel, after over 10,000 miles, has almost seen it all. He will jump into action and fix what he can. Don't fret if he looks stressed fixing things, deep down he truly enjoys it. Feed him, bring him a drink, and he will take care of the boat. We also have a very helpful co-skipper Justin who is always just a call and flight away.

Her name

Windigo was our favourite family ski run at Mont Tremblant. It's one of those runs you remember — in the woods, bumps, fun, and just technical enough to keep you honest. The name stuck with us long before there was a boat.

There's also the mythological reference.

The "Wendigo" (sometimes spelled Windigo) is a creature from Algonquian Indigenous folklore in North America. It's often associated with the forests of the Great Lakes region and eastern Canada. While people sometimes loosely connect it to the Huron/Wendat, the stories are more broadly part of Algonquian traditions rather than one specific nation.

In mythology, the Wendigo is usually described as a powerful spirit of the wilderness, something elemental, tied to nature, cold, and raw forces. We're not claiming the darker parts of the legend. We just appreciate the connection to Canadian heritage, wilderness, and something bigger than ourselves.

And then there's the simple explanation. It has "wind" and "go" in the name. Which, conveniently, describes exactly how we like to travel. Wind. Go. That's the idea.

Moving Around the Boat Underway

If we are sailing and you want to go forward onto the foredeck, please ask first. There are seats up front when it's calm and you can also lay down on the trampoline. Conditions change. Loads change. Sometimes it's perfectly fine. Sometimes it's not.

If you go forward:

- Hold onto railings at all times.
- Move slowly.
- Keep low.
- Never step inside loops of rope.

It will always be weather dependent. When in doubt, ask.

If we think the trip will be bumpy, we have Gravol and sea sickness tablets. Just ask if you know that you get woozy with sea movement.

Departure Procedure

Before we get underway, we make sure the boat is secure. That means:

- The tender is properly lifted and secured.
- All hatches are closed and dogged tight.
- Loose items are secured.
- Clothing is removed from lifelines and rails.
- The swim ladder is up.
- No loose lines are in the water.
- Water toys are stored and secured.
- Nothing is hanging overboard.

We don’t rush departures. A clean deck is a safe deck. If you see something not at its place let us know.

Heads (aka Toilets)

These are marine heads, not household toilets.

If you didn’t eat it or drink it, it does not go in. No wipes, paper towels, hygiene products, or anything “almost flushable.” Toilet paper is fine in reasonable amounts.

For #1 Don't bother pressing the “Before” button as it wastes water. Just go and press “After”. For #2, press “Before” to fill and “After” to flush.

If something seems unusual — slow draining, resistance, odd sounds — tell me immediately. Plumbing issues on boats escalate quickly.

Water

You can drink the tank water. It is filtered and safe. Water is finite, though. We carry what we carry. Showers should be short. If we have been motoring we will have hot water otherwise the water temperature will be the same as the air. Wet down, turn off water, soap, rinse. That's normal on boats.

Turn taps off while brushing teeth. Don't let sinks run unnecessarily. Every litre saved gives us more flexibility and more time at anchor.

Why is the water so flat? Funny you ask. Our water maker works with seawater that first passes through a 20-micron pre-filter, which removes larger suspended solids—sand grains, bits of shell, plankton, and general ocean crud. Then it goes through a 5-micron carbon or sediment filter, which strips out finer particulates and many organic compounds that could foul the membrane. By the time the water reaches the reverse osmosis (RO) stage, most physical debris and a chunk of biological load are already gone. That protects the heart of the system: the semi-permeable RO membrane.

The RO membrane is where the physics magic happens. It's engineered with pores on the order of ~0.0001 microns—small enough to block bacteria, protozoa, and even most viruses, along with dissolved salts and minerals like sodium, magnesium, and calcium. High pressure (typically 600–800 psi in seawater systems) forces water molecules through the membrane while rejecting 95–99% of dissolved solids. What comes out the "product" side is microbiologically safe and extremely low in total dissolved solids (TDS). That's why it's potable but also tastes "flat": the same mechanism that removes pathogens also strips out the minerals that give spring

water its flavor and buffering capacity. You're essentially drinking H_2O that's been sieved at the molecular scale—clean, but mineral-minimalist by design.

We have electrolyte tablets that you can add to the water if you want a less-flat taste.

Drinks

We keep the fridges and freezer for food but you're lucky… we also have a dedicated drink fridge. Take a drink out of the fridge and then put one back. We all want cold drinks. So if you take some out, put some back in so that you're not the one with a big thirst tomorrow with no drinks in the drinks fridge.

Dishwasher

We have a dishwasher. Use it. It is more water-efficient than handwashing badly. Load it properly. Run it when it's reasonably full. This is one of the few modern luxuries onboard. Take advantage of it. Use the "Auto" cycle which runs for 2h30m.

If you notice the dishwasher has finished a cycle please empty it. It's not a huge galley, you'll find a good spot for things quickly.

MFDs

MFDs is the shorthand for multi-function-displays which is what we use to navigate. We have three of them and feel free to use them.

You can pinch, scroll and explore the maps. Moving on one screen doesn't impact the others. So if we are sailing or motoring, Jean-Michel is using the one at the upper helm and won't be affected if you use the others. Just don't turn off the auto pilot. That's the main hazard. Don't click on anything called "Pilot" and you're fine.

You'll also see all the geeky data that we use to navigate safely. Wind speeds, boat speeds, wind angles. Outside we have histograms above the saloon entry we have histograms to track wind changes over time.

Air Conditioning and Hatches

We have air conditioning in each cabin, and we have opening hatches. We do not use both at the same time. If the AC is running, hatches and doors stay closed.

If the AC is off, open hatches are great with any breeze. If it rains, you'll know quickly and you can simply close then. Just make sure they are secured before we sail or if rain is coming.

To turn on the AC press the bottom-left button and it will turn green. It's a tad hard to see, but you'll also hear the water pump and fans turn on. Generally, keeping the temperature at 25c will be enough to remove humidity and sleep well. The display shows the current temperature and after you've turned on you can press one of the temperature adjust buttons to see the cooling temperature.

Hanging Gear and Loose Items

Wet towels and swimsuits hang outside on designated lines. Not on winches, not on sail controls. We have clothe pins in a container behind the nav station. Put at least 4 pins on each item and if you keep the items more aft (aka the back) of the boat the wind can be a tad lighter than in the front.

If you're unsure where something goes, ask. When sailing, nothing should be loose. Anything unsecured can move quickly if the boat accelerates or stops.

Garbage and Recycling

Storage space for garbage is limited. The main garbage is in the galley to the right of the sink. Separate recyclables where possible into the back bin and regular into the front one with the white garbage bags. Crush cans and flatten boxes.

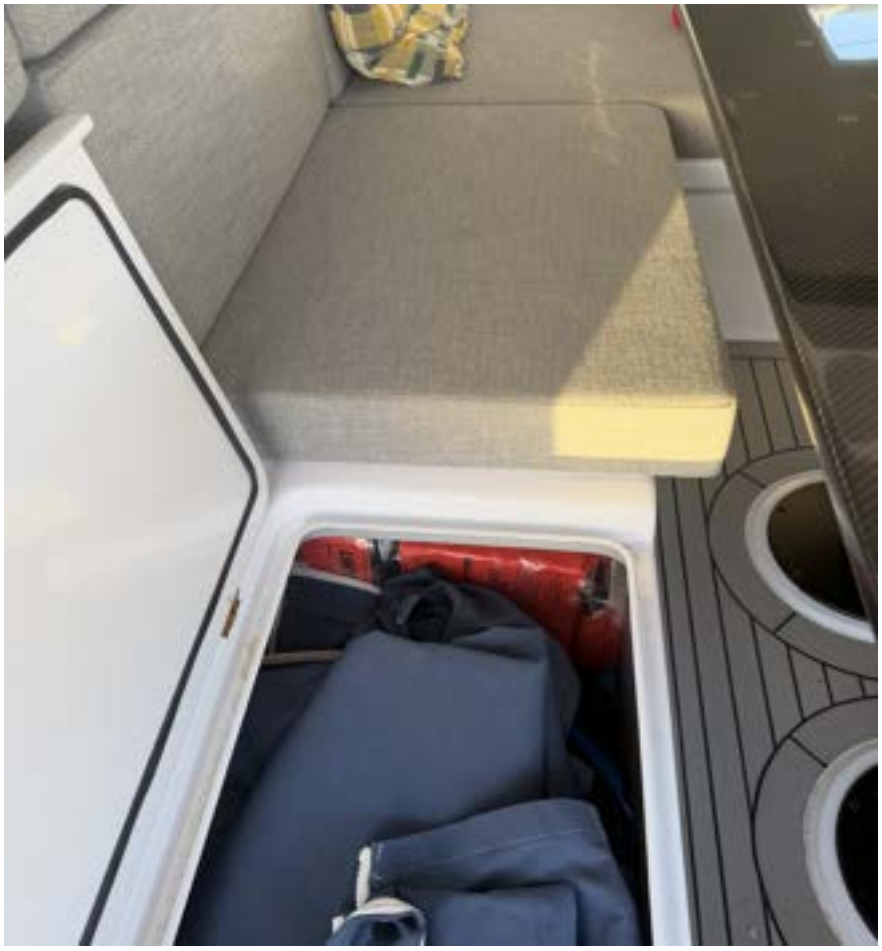
The other thing that goes overboard is compost (e.g. organics) once we are underway. Nothing else goes overboard. Ever.

Lines and Winches

Lines under load can carry thousands of pounds of force. Do not step inside a loop of rope. Do not wrap a line around your hand. Keep fingers clear of loaded winches. If you're unsure whether something is under load, assume it is. Wait for instructions before handling sail controls. Coordination matters.

Life Jackets

Life jackets are located inside the seat at the helm station. These are our sailing vests and what we wear on crossings and when offshore. But we also have 8 life-vests under the bench in the cockpit.



If conditions feel uncomfortable — rough weather, docking, night sailing — put one on.

Inflatable jackets deploy with the pull tab. There is also a manual inflation tube.

We have 4 paddleboard and tender life vests in a bag in the front of the tender. They go around your waist and can be inflated by hand.

VHF Radio

We have 4 VHF radios. Two of them are fixed to the boat, one is inside at the nav desk and the other outside at the upper helm. Channel 16 is for emergency and hailing. They are always left on channel 16. That’s the international hailing channel and we have a responsibility to help others around us who may need a hand.

In a serious emergency:

“Mayday, Mayday, Mayday.
 This is Windigo.
 Our position is [GPS coordinates].
 Nature of emergency is…
 Number of people onboard is…”

Speak clearly and slowly.

We also have two handhelds that we often bring when we go on hikes and visiting so that we can talk to each other.

Flares

Flares are located under the bbq in a water tight container. They are for genuine distress only. Point them away from the boat and downwind. They burn extremely hot. If we abandon ship we take the entire container with us into the life raft.

Medical Kit

We have 2 offshore medical kits that are very well equipped. We have antibiotics, pain killers and more. We are almost equipped to perform a triple bypass, but that likely won't happen. We have 24/7 access to a doctor by phone and there's a medical emergency handbook in the bookshelf behind the nav station.

The first medical kit is in the aft locked in the cockpit, the second is in the bilge on starboard near the door going into the aft cabin.

If someone is seriously injured, we stop and deal with it immediately. Control bleeding first. Use VHF Channel 16 if life-threatening.

Swimming

Best is to wait until the boat is stopped before jumping into the water. We may not turn back to get you. But once we are stopped, cool down quickly! We also have a lot of toys to put in the water so give us a hand.

There's often current off the back of the boat. Tie up all the toys and ensure you test out the current before venturing too far out. The swim ladder can be pulled out from the deck or from the water. Move the metal knob and pull out the latter with some force.

We have two transom showers that are flush with each hull. The on/off button is at the opposite end from the water jet. Feel free to rinse off and get that salt off your carefully sculpted body! Be gentle with the shower handles. Put them back with the jet facing up (look carefully at the

Internet

This is one of those decisions that only you can make. We have unlimited internet onboard, mostly because we work from the boat and watch sports and tv. But it's your vacation, you should spend time outside, look at the horizon, and daydream.

But if you have to take a work video call or meeting, or just Facetime someone. Go ahead, don't worry about it.

SSID: Windigo
Password: Netlogix@012

Music

Windigo has over 1800 watts of pure beautiful sound. Two subwoofers bring the bass to any EDM you want to play. Feel free to be a DJ, use the iPad at the helm which has Spotify and it automatically connects to the JLAudio at the nav station.

The password for the iPad is **580002**.

The volume always starts off, so when you're playing a song, turn it up. There's also a sound control in the cockpit beside the handheld VHF.

Engines

We have two engines. Well, technically we have 3 because we also have a powerful bow thruster in the port hull. But you won't get to play with that one!

To start:

Ensure throttles are in neutral. Press the On button, wait for the buttons to flash green once, then press start and keep your finger on start for 1-2 seconds until the engine is running. You'll hear it.
Confirm water is flowing from the exhaust.

If there is no water flow, shut the engine down immediately.

Use smooth, small throttle movements.

To turn off, press stop, then the power button when you hear the engine has stopped.

If I Am Incapacitated

If I'm unable to manage the boat, the first goal is to reduce speed and simplify things.

Turn into the wind. Start the engines asap.

Furl the headsail steadily. Both headsails can be furled from the upper helm. One has a furling line and the other (genoa) is a hydraulic powered with buttons labelled at the helm “<<” to furl “Free” to unfurl.

Ease the mainsheet and drop the main. To drop the main, first release the outhaul, then the main downhaul / cunningham, then raise the main halyard about 10cm you’ll hear a beep this removes it from the lock, then lower slowly all the way down.

Reducing sail reduces stress.

Call VHF 16 and ask for help. Use “PAN-PAN PAN-PAN PAN-PAN. Windigo sailing catamaran at <GPS location from VHF radio or chart plotter> our captain is <explain nature of emergency>. Any boats in the vicinity please help.”

The Tender

The dinghy is our transport to shore. Balance weight evenly. Attach the kill cord when driving. Move carefully when boarding. When we lift or lower it, follow instructions and keep clear of lines and lifting points.

Very important, **never put a body part or fingers between you and the tender or boat**. The tender has padding and can take a bump. But you can’t. Be careful getting on and off the boat. Don’t rush it, if it’s lumpy wait for the right time and get low when getting on and off the tender.

Cooking and Shared Work

We have a full home size kitchen, so cook like you’re a chef on a super yacht! We will all enjoy it. The oven is also a microwave. The induction cooktop works wonders, wipe with hot water to clean. No cleaning products on it please.

Storage and refrigeration space are limited. Clean as you go. If something needs doing and you’re able to do it, just do it.

We also have a broom and fancy Dyson. If you see dirt, feel free to help out and clean up a bit.

Windigo University

You don’t have to learn anything. You can relax the entire trip if you prefer. But if you want to, here’s what you can walk away knowing how to do:

- Launch and secure the tender properly.

- Tie a bowline, a clove hitch, and a figure eight knot.
- Handle basic sail controls under instruction.
- Start and stop the engines correctly.
- Put the swim ladder down and secure it.
- Understand departure and arrival procedures.
- Drive the tender.
- Anchoring and raising the anchor.
- Tying up and releasing from a mooring ball.
- Make excellent drinks at anchor.

You'll leave more capable than you arrived. That's part of the fun.

Packing up

All good things come to an end and we hope you enjoyed your stay on Windigo. Housekeeping unfortunately does not come aboard and at times there may be a short turnover between guests. Your efforts at leaving your cabin and head the same way you found them are greatly appreciated! Ask for cleaning supplies and we will oblige.

Final Note

Windigo is a capable, well-engineered boat. She performs best when the people onboard are paying attention and working together. We love having guests and enjoying time in close quarters with our family and friends. You aren't in our way. We love having you.

But we're not running a hotel. We're running a small, mobile city in open water. Respect the boat, respect each other, and this will be a trip worth repeating.

Bienvenue abord!